

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

▲ CHARANJIT SINGH CHANNI, *61*

| CONGRESS | *Jalandhar (SC), Punjab*

He came as a surprise choice when the Congress thought it fit to dethrone Amarinder Singh in 2021—and was much feted as Punjab's first Dalit CM, one who replaced erstwhile royalty at that. Later, lamented as one who perhaps didn't get much time to turn things around, before the AAP storm hit in the 2022 assembly poll. Losing from two constituencies, Channi was briefly threatened by oblivion. But he has renewed his claim on relevance by winning from the Doaba belt, the epicentre of Punjab's Dalit politics, and will be in sync with the Congress's larger national quest now.



ANI

JAGADISH SHETTAR, *68* ▶

| BJP | *Belagavi, Karnataka*

His uncle Sadashiv Shettar was the Jana Sangh's first legislator in the South, elected to the Karnataka Legislative Council in 1967; his dad wore saffron too, as a five-time corporator and mayor. So it was against deep filial bonds, and with a heavy heart, that ex-CM Jagadish Shettar moved to the Congress in 2023 ahead of the assembly polls. Though electoral luck eluded him then, it was seen as a high-profile sign of Lingayat disaffection. Order was restored with a *ghar wapsi* for the mild-mannered former lawyer in January. Repairs to electoral honour followed.

NARAYAN RANE, *72* ▼

| BJP | *Ratnagiri-Sindhudurg, Maharashtra*

The former Shiv Sainik from Chembur earned his spurs as a street fighter in a party known for its rough-and-ready politics. In 1990, he graduated from Mumbai local body lordship to state politics with a victory from Sindhudurg. There, on the Konkan coast, he developed a political fief good enough to pitchfork him to the CM's post, albeit briefly, in 1999. In 2005, he quit the Shiv Sena after a protracted power struggle with Uddhav Thackeray. Thwarted ambition dogged him through a stint with the Congress and his own political start-up. The BJP awaited as the last refuge.



HINDUSTAN TIMES